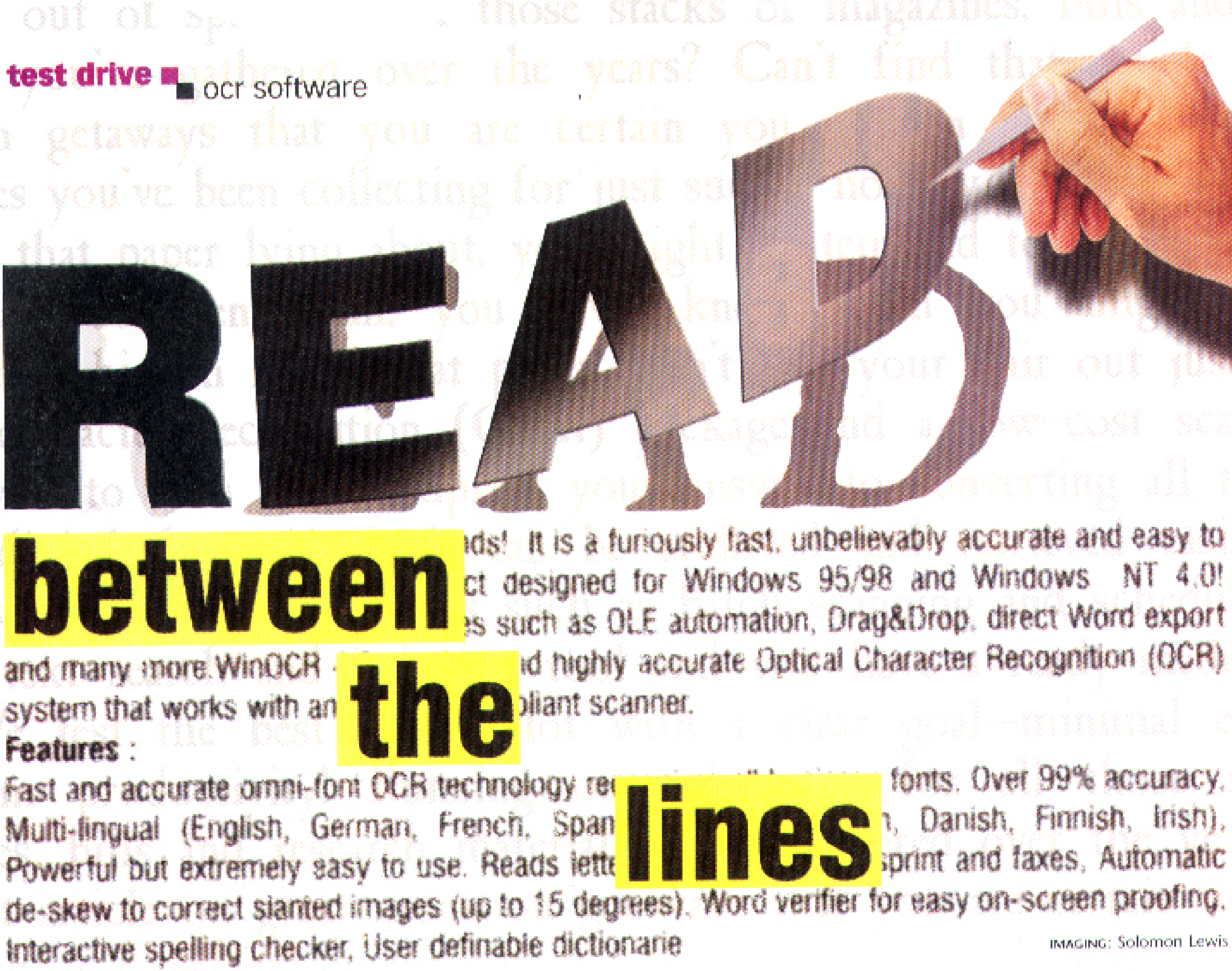
READ between the lines



IMAGING: Solomon Lewis

We test the best OCR software that promise to convert all the information stored on paper into an editable, searchable digital database

Running out of space for all those stacks of magazines, bills and research material you've gathered over the years? Can't find that article on great monsoon getaways that you are certain you saw in one of those travel magazines you've been collecting? In a fit of irritation with all that paper lying about, you might be tempted to sell it off to the *raddiwala*, but you never know when you might need the information hidden in there.

Don't tear your hair out just yet. An optical character recognition (OCR) package and a low-cost scanner that allows you to scan at 300 dpi is your answer to converting all that information on paper into a digital format, which can be archived and retrieved easily. OCR packages today include features such as batch scanning and scheduling. A text search and indexing tool completes the picture!

We test the best of the lot with a clear goal—minimal effort and maximum productivity!

Test process

The test bed used to evaluate the OCR software consisted of a Pentium III 700 MHz processor, 128 MB RAM and an 8.5 GB 5,400 rpm hard drive. We used a scanner with 24-bit colour depth and a resolution of 600x1200 dpi—you would need just 300 dpi and 24-bit colour for any OCR software to recognise fonts accurately. The test documents were scanned with default settings and saved to Microsoft Word 2000 and Excel.

Before testing each OCR package, we loaded Windows 98SE on a cleanly formatted system. Cacheman 5.11 logged the memory usage of the OCR software.

We tested the OCR software on the following parameters:

Performance: We looked for the accuracy with which the OCR engine could recognise words, characters and symbols and its ability to retain the original layout and formatting.

Another measure of good performance is the OCR software's ability to deal with many kinds of documents, some involving complex formatting and others that are smudged or have faded text. Hence, we challenged the OCR packages with a set of nine documents: a regular word document printed on an inkjet printer, a combination document with various ASCII characters and symbols, an Excel sheet with complex table formatting, a dot matrix print, photocopy of a word document, a type-written sheet, a fax copy, a newspaper sheet, and a magazine page with complex formatting.

Features: The feature set of an OCR software adds to its functionality. The features that matter include multiple language support, table recognition, scheduling and batch processing, support